



IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Drama

DIRECTOR

Henri-Georges Clouzot

WRITERS

Henri-Georges Clouzot, Jérôme Geronimi (screenplay); Georges Arnaud (novel)

STARS

Yves Montand, Charles Vanel, Peter van Eyck, Folco Lulli

BEFORE

1943 Clouzot's caustic drama *Le Corbeau* tells the story of a poison-pen writer who signs his missives "The Raven."

1947 Clouzot's third movie, *Quai des Orfèvres*, is a crime drama set in postwar Paris.

AFTER

1955 In Clouzot's taut and twist-filled *Les Diaboliques*, two women take revenge on a sadistic headmaster.

WHEN I WAS A KID, I USED TO SEE MEN GO OFF ON THESE KIND OF JOBS—AND NOT COME BACK

THE WAGES OF FEAR / 1953

Henri-Georges Clouzot's *The Wages of Fear* is a juggernaut of suspense driven by greed and desperation. A contemporary and friendly rival of Alfred Hitchcock, Clouzot succeeds in gripping the viewer with a nerve-wracking story. Four men, Mario (Yves Montand), Jo (Charles Vanel), Luigi (Folco Lulli), and Bimba (Peter van Eyck), are desperate to escape life in a grim South American

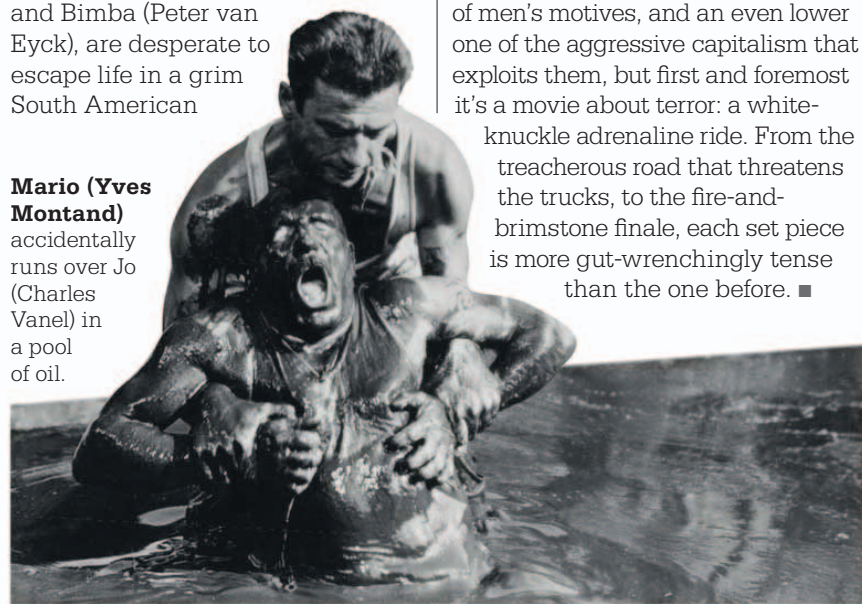
village. When they are hired by a ruthless US oil company, they think it's their ticket out. But they are told to drive trucks of nitroglycerine across a wilderness of potholes, crumbling ledges, and rickety bridges to put out an oil fire hundreds of miles away. Not everyone is expected to make it back alive.

The movie exhibits a low opinion of men's motives, and an even lower one of the aggressive capitalism that exploits them, but first and foremost it's a movie about terror: a white-

knuckle adrenaline ride. From the treacherous road that threatens the trucks, to the fire-and-brimstone finale, each set piece is more gut-wrenchingly tense than the one before. ■

Mario (Yves Montand)

accidentally runs over Jo (Charles Vanel) in a pool of oil.



What else to watch: *Le Corbeau* (1943) ■ *Eyes Without a Face* (1960) ■ *Henri-Georges Clouzot's Inferno* (1964) ■ *Duel* (1971)